Cuban government continued unabated. Only days after promising Khrushchev that the United States would abandon any further attempt to invade the island, the Pentagon was preparing a document to qualify the pledge. "The president had promised to forego only an 'armed seizure by U.S. forces,' " political scientist Lars Schoultz explains, summarizing and quoting the document, "while other actions such as a 'Bay-of-Pigs-type operation' had not been ruled out." Meanwhile Kennedy told his advisors that the promise had been a sham, and that "our objective is to preserve our right to invade Cuba."[66]

Robert S. McNamara summarized the changes in the scholarship after the 2002 conference. "For many years, I considered the Cuban Missile Crisis to be the best-managed foreign policy crisis of the last half-century." Instead, revelations in the documents and at the two conferences revealed a shocking degree of ignorance, miscommunication, bravado, and pure chance in the course of events. McNamara acknowledged that the missiles in no way affected the balance of power. Kennedy, however, felt obligated to respond with force because he was trapped by earlier statements he had made threatening action in the event of such a development. At the 1992 conference Soviet General Anatoly Gribkov revealed that 162 nuclear warheads had been installed in Cuba prior to the U.S. naval blockade, and Fidel Castro declared that Cuba had been prepared to use them, had the United States attacked. In fact, in the very midst of the crisis, MONGOOSE leaders had dispatched three sabotage teams to Cuba, and had 10 more ready to depart.[67] The brink was far closer than either the public at the time, or later historians, had realized.

The crisis, and its resolution, also shook the foundations of Cuba's developing relationship with the Soviet Union. Khrushchev's decision to withdraw the missiles was made without any consultation with the Cubans, who felt that once again, their sovereignty was being made hostage to great power politics. "People went out in the streets singing *congas*," recalled one observer, "chanting 'Niquita, mariquita, lo que se da ¡no se quita!' " [Loosely: "Nikita, faggot, what you give you can't take away!"].[68]